EW AVATAR



TEMPLE RUN
Construction in progress at the Ram Janmabhoomi site, Sept. 4

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

MUCH WATER HAS FLOWED DOWN the Sarayu since Ayodhya first became the centre of a dispute as long as the history of independent India itself. It gave birth to a violent politico-religious movement that divided the country till the November 9, 2019 Supreme Court verdict on Ayodhya settled the matter. The disputed 2.77 acres of land was handed to a trust that would oversee the construction of the Ram temple. Nine months later, on August 5, 2020, Prime Minister Narendra Modi was presiding over the ground-breaking ceremony of the temple.

After years of unrest, has Ayodhya finally found peace? The temple town today is bustling with activity, as the 'double-engine BJP *sarkar*' (at the Centre and in Uttar Pradesh) strives to have the temple ready in time for electoral dividend, particularly the big prize—a third chance at governing the country in the 2024 parliamentary election.

The urgency shows. "The construction work of the temple has been expedited," says Champat Rai, general secretary of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, which was constituted at the apex court's behest to oversee the construction of the temple. "The goal of the trust is to complete the construction of